

all the Dutchman needed to do was stay ahead of his British counterpart, and he completed the straightforward task without much fuss.

There may have been some relief for Verstappen after closing out the championship battle. A flame seemed to have reignited, one that was nearly snuffed out by an uncommon mid-season glut. **Despite initially lacking pace, he pieced together a perfect lap to start at the front of the grid for the penultimate race in Qatar.**

His first pole position in five months was short-lived after a rare one-place penalty for impeding Russell, the driver who started alongside him. But it was no hindrance to Verstappen or his surprising pace, as he led from the first lap to finish at the Lusail International Circuit, taking his ninth win of the season. The sprint race, however, told a different story.

It was yet another commanding drive by both McLaren drivers, with pole-sitter Norris letting his teammate Oscar Piastri go by in the nick of time for the victory. The 25-year-old paid no heed to team orders as he repaid the favour from the Brazil affair, back when he was on a mission to chase Verstappen for the title.

In the main race, Norris had a good start and maintained a minimal gap to the driver ahead, Verstappen. However, he was slapped with a harsh 10-second stop/go penalty, effectively losing 35 seconds and dropping to the back of the grid, wiping out any shot he had at taking the lead.

Though he may have fallen short of the ask, it was undoubtedly Norris' best season thus far, aided by a much stronger, faster McLaren. Playing the team game prevailed in the end, as the Woking-based unit inched

closer to its first World Constructors' Championship (WCC) since 1998. Nevertheless, if this topsy-turvy nine-month spectacle has taught fans anything, it's that there's always a new contender just around the corner.

Ferrari has been a consistent side, gradually climbing through the points. **The Italian outfit is within striking distance — 21 points — of leader McLaren, with a maximum of 44 up for grabs in the finale.** They are the only teams left in the WCC fight, as Red Bull was eliminated, losing out on crucial points due to the lack of contributions from Sergio Perez, who has

Fast lane: Verstappen led from the first lap to finish at the Lusail International Circuit, taking his ninth win of the season at the Qatar Grand Prix. GETTY IMAGES

endured a miserable time in the midfield. With only one no-result race, Ferrari has managed to score an average of 26.9 points combined, compared to McLaren's 27.8, with five race wins between its two drivers, Charles Leclerc (3) and Carlos Sainz (2). While the latter will find himself behind the steering wheel of a Williams in 2025, with seven-time world champion Hamilton taking his place, Leclerc has pulled up into the final-race tussle for second place with Norris.

Only eight points separate the two as the F1 contingent lands at its curtain-closer destination, Abu Dhabi.

The Yas Marina Circuit will see the fight for second place in the WDC and, more importantly, the constructors' championship, unfold. With the track favouring Ferrari, it could be eyeing its first WCC title in 16 years, while McLaren aims for its first in 26. A thrilling end awaits, as the stage is all set for a showdown that will declare a new champion and celebrate a peerless one.



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